NARRATION SCRIPT | AUDIO EDITION

47,454 Results Withheld: Cheating, Catching, or Paperwork?

Written by Fomba Kassoh. Voiced with AI.

Imagine a student in Bo, or Makeni, or Kenema, or Freetown. She sat her final exams in May and June. She has waited all summer. On Tuesday the results come out. She types in her number, and instead of grades, one word comes up on the screen. Withheld

On Tuesday, the twenty-seventh of October, two thousand and twenty-six, that word appeared for forty-seven thousand, four hundred and fifty-four candidates in Sierra Leone. Their entire results were held back over suspected examination malpractice. It is the largest number in the country's recent record, and it arrives right in the middle of university admissions season

I'm Fomba Kassoh. I'm a data scientist, and over the past weeks I went through every published figure on withheld results in Sierra Leone, from two thousand and eighteen to this week. Ministry statements, WAEC releases, and the one detailed official case report that has been made public. In this episode I want to walk you through what those numbers can tell us, what they cannot, and what families are owed

Let me say one thing clearly at the start. This is not an argument that cheating is imaginary, or that enforcement should be relaxed. Cheating is real, and it hurts every honest student. This is an argument about clarity. When a system holds back tens of thousands of results in a year, people deserve to know why, and what happened next

---

So let's start with the word itself. Withheld

Under WAEC's rules, withheld is meant to be temporary. It means a result is on hold while a case is investigated. If the committee finds a candidate guilty, the result is cancelled, either for one subject or for everything. If not, the result is released

But here is the first thing the data shows. In practice, the same word on a results screen can mean at least six different things

It can mean the candidate is suspected of cheating. Collusion, a phone in the hall, notes, answers shared on social media

It can mean someone on the inside is suspected. In recent years the Anti-Corruption Commission has indicted WAEC staff, including senior examiners and a computer programmer, over alleged changes to scripts and grades.

Those are allegations before the courts, not findings. But they remind us that integrity problems are not only about students

It can mean the school never sent in the student's continuous assessment scores, the part of the grade that comes from schoolwork

It can mean a problem with registration. A name that couldn't be verified, or a candidate who shouldn't have been registered at all

It can mean the school owed WAEC money and hadn't paid

Or it can simply mean the result is still being processed

Only the first two involve anyone's alleged misconduct. And only the first involves the student's own conduct. In the other four, the young person is carrying the delay for an adult's failure, or a system's

---

You can see this most clearly at the primary level. In August, one thousand, nine hundred and twenty-seven NPSE results were set aside. To many people, that sounded like children cheating. But the Minister explained that the main cause was schools failing to submit continuous assessment records

On the figures that were reported, about one thousand, six hundred results were held for missing assessment records, and a few hundred for unpaid fees. That means roughly eighty-five out of every hundred primary pupils held back were held because of paperwork their school didn't send. Not because of anything the child did

That is why the word matters. When every case is called withheld, every child sounds like a suspect

---

Now, the second question. How big is the problem, really

The counts themselves are clear. About thirty-four and a half thousand withheld in two thousand and twenty-three. About twenty-seven thousand in two thousand and twenty-four. About thirteen thousand in two thousand and twenty-five. And now, more than forty-seven thousand

But a count is not a rate. To get a rate, you divide by the number of candidates. And here is the problem. Each year, the announcements used a different number to divide by. Sometimes everyone who entered. Sometimes everyone who registered. Sometimes everyone on the results list. Sometimes only those who actually sat the papers

That choice changes the answer. This year, the forty-seven thousand is about one in four of everyone registered. But

not everyone who registers actually sits the exam. Last year, about one in four candidates on the results list didn't sit a single paper. If something like that happened again this year, then among students who actually sat, the share withheld could be close to one in three

One in four, or one in three. We can't say which, because the number of candidates who actually sat this year hasn't been published. And that is the first simple thing that should change. Publish how many sat, every year, right next to how many were withheld

---

The third question is the hardest. Is more cheating happening, or is more cheating being caught

Any count of withheld results mixes those two things together. Better supervision, or better checking of scripts during marking, can push the number up even if students behave exactly the same. And weaker checking can push it down

Here is what makes this difficult. Last year, when the number fell, the fall was credited to stricter monitoring. This year, when the number rose sharply, the rise was explained the same way, as stricter monitoring catching more cases. In fairness, the Ministry also said the size of the increase needs investigating

Both statements might be true in their own year. But an explanation that fits a fall and a rise equally well can't tell the public which one is really happening

The one detailed official report we have, from two thousand and twenty, gives a clue about why this matters. In two thousand and eighteen, collusion, meaning students copying from each other, made up a small share of reported cases. In two thousand and nineteen, there were no collusion cases recorded at all. Then in two thousand and twenty, collusion suddenly made up sixty out of every hundred cases

Did students change their behaviour that much in one year? Possibly. But a whole category vanishing and then becoming the majority looks at least as much like a change in how cases were detected or recorded. The published data can't tell the difference. And without knowing how each case was found, neither can anyone else

The Ministry has promised to publish a breakdown of thirteen reasons behind this year's holds. That will be the most useful piece of information we have had in years. It should be published every year, not just this one

---

The fourth question. What happens after a hold

Here we have one clear piece of history. In two thousand and twenty, about four thousand, two hundred and seventy candidates were reported for irregularities. That was under three in every hundred who sat

The examinations committee reviewed every case. About one thousand, one hundred lost their entire results. About three thousand, one hundred lost one or more subjects. Forty-one were sent for further investigation. And not a single reported candidate was cleared

Two things stand out. First, in two thousand and twenty, being reported almost always ended in some penalty. Second, nearly three out of every four cases ended with a subject cancelled, not the whole result

This year, all forty-seven thousand holds are holds on entire results. If two thousand and twenty is any guide, many of these cases may end with a penalty on one subject. But while the investigation runs, the hold blocks everything. Every subject. Every application. Every deadline

And this is the gap. We have that outcome report for two thousand and twenty. We have not found an equivalent for any year since. Sierra Leone publishes the count. It does not yet publish the outcome

There is one more question the numbers raise, and I want to be careful with it

In February, the Minister said schools had uploaded around two hundred and nineteen thousand names to the registration system. About seventy-four thousand of them could not be verified at first, and he described some of that as an attempt to get around the BECE checks. After a clean-up, fifty-five thousand names were still unmatched

By October, the register stood at just over two hundred and one thousand. That is around thirty-seven thousand more than the number cleared by February

I am not saying the withheld students and those extra registrations are the same people. The public data cannot show that. But it is a fair question, and only the Ministry's own records can answer it. How many of the forty-seven thousand came from names that were unmatched in February? If the answer is many, then Sierra Leone may have a registration problem dressed up as a cheating problem. If the answer is few, we can rule that out. Either way, families deserve to know

The government has announced a unique learner identification system to catch students registered in more than one school. That is the right tool, and its first findings should be made public

How does Sierra Leone compare with its neighbours

We are not alone. Nigeria withheld more than twenty out of every hundred results in two thousand and twenty-two. But Nigeria's rate has fallen every year since, to under nine in a hundred this year. Liberia withheld under four in a hundred last year. The Gambia, about half of one percent this year

What stands out about Sierra Leone is not just the level. It is how much it swings. Up, down, and now sharply up again

Ghana is harder to compare, because it reports in a different way. It separates whole results, single subjects, and entire schools under review. That actually tells the public more, not less. And Nigeria reports cases still being processed separately from suspected cheating, and announces when cleared students' results are released

So what should change. Here are eight simple promises, and several of them build on commitments the government has already made

One. Every results announcement should include one clear table, separating suspected cheating, school failures, registration problems, unpaid fees, and cases still being processed

Two. Publish outcomes, not just holds. Sixty days after results come out, and again at a hundred and twenty days, tell the public how many were cleared, how many lost a subject, how many lost everything, and how many are still waiting

Three. Hold only what the evidence touches. If an allegation concerns one paper, hold that subject and release the rest, unless the rules truly require otherwise

Four. Set a deadline for investigations, and fast-track students with university or college deadlines. A hold that outlasts the admissions season becomes a punishment in itself, whatever the committee decides later

Five. Sanction adults for adult failures. When a school fails to send assessment scores, registers students wrongly, or doesn't pay fees it has collected, the principal or proprietor should answer for it, and the student's result should be released as soon as the record can be checked. That matters most for primary pupils, who are children

Six. Match the register to the holds, school by school, and publish what it shows

Seven. The new WAEC bill planned for two thousand and twenty-seven should do more than create new offences. It should guarantee that every student is told the allegation,

gets a chance to respond, receives a reasoned decision, has a route to appeal, and gets an answer within a set time

And eight. Publish the data each year in a form anyone can download and check

The government has already promised faster investigations, independent observers at committee hearings, action against principals involved in repeated malpractice, and that new law. These eight steps would make those promises measurable

---

Before I close, a word to families who are living this right now

If your child's result shows withheld, it does not mean they have been found guilty. It means a case is under review. You can check the status on the WAEC Sierra Leone website. Ask your child's school whether its continuous assessment records were submitted and whether its fees to WAEC were paid, because either of those can hold a result. And if your child has an admissions deadline, tell the university or college that the result is withheld pending investigation, and keep copies of everything

---

Forty-seven thousand, four hundred and fifty-four. Behind that number are young people waiting to find out whether

their next step can begin. Some will be found to have cheated, and they should face the consequences. Many may not. A fair system is one that finds out quickly, explains clearly, and lets the innocent move on

Cheating, catching, or paperwork. Right now, the public can't tell which. That is the one thing that can change fastest

The full paper, with every chart and every source, is available from The Green Professionals. I'm Fomba Kassoh. Thank you for listening